



BEFORE

By 1860, America had some 30,000 miles (48,280km) of railroad tracks, mostly owned by a dozen prominent companies.

NORTHERN DEVELOPMENTS

Every year, **new engine designs increased the power of locomotives** and also their load capacity. In the North, where **industry and population centers demanded rapid transit** and banks wanted to invest in the infrastructure, **railroads flourished** and expanded.

SOUTHERN RAILROADS

The railroads of the South were chiefly built **to transport cash crops**, such as cotton, from plantations to riverfront depots or seaports. **Track gauges were often incompatible** between lines, and there was a shortage of locomotives. Few railroads crossed state borders or rivers.

In the first year of the war, the Lincoln administration recognized the need for an overarching authority to harness the power of the Northern railroads. The Railroad and Telegraph Act, passed on January 31, 1862, gave President Lincoln full authority to nationalize any railroad and impress its equipment or employees into federal service. The War Department wasted no time in creating the United States Military Railroads (U.S.M.R.R.) in February, and Lincoln placed Daniel C. McCallum, an experienced railroad administrator, at its head. McCallum and the U.S.M.R.R coordinated all rail supply of the federal armies with the private companies. They also repaired and made use of damaged Southern railways, as well as building and operating military lines.

Assisting McCallum in his task was a retinue of officers and directors, of whom the most prominent was the German-born Herman Haupt, the U.S.M.R.R's chief of construction and maintenance in Virginia. Through most of 1862 and 1863, Haupt supplied several Union armies by railroads. In the Second Bull Run campaign, General Stonewall Jackson destroyed a critical bridge in northern Virginia, which temporarily crippled Union resupply efforts. Haupt and his motley crew of railroad workers, engineers, and contraband slaves repaired the bridge in two weeks using only green lumber and saplings. This feat prompted Lincoln to say, "I have seen the most remarkable structure that human eyes ever rested upon. That man, Haupt, has built a bridge ... over which